ENGLISH · TEST PREP · 12 OCTOBER

Short Stories.

Everything you need for the test – features, summary writing and narrative perspectives – plus practice tasks, a full mock test and an answer key.

You've got this! ★

01 Features of short stories

02 Writing a summary

03 Narrative perspectives

Test: ~45 minutes

Practice · Mock test · Answers

01

TOPIC ONE

Features of a Short Story

A short story is a **short piece of fiction** that can usually be read in one sitting. Because it is short, everything is reduced and concentrated: one main event, few people, one place, a short time.

1 Limited length

Can be read in one go (often 1–20 pages). Every detail matters.

2 Few characters

Usually 1 protagonist + a few minor characters. Often only little background information.

3 One setting

Only one or very few places (e.g. a kitchen, a bus stop).

4 Short time span

The action covers minutes, hours or a few days – not years.

5 Sudden / open beginning

Starts *in medias res* ("in the middle of things") – no long introduction.

6 One main conflict

A single plot line, often focused on one key moment or problem.

7 Turning point

A moment where things change – often a **moment of insight** (epiphany) for the protagonist.

8 Open or surprise ending

Often no clear solution – the reader has to think further. Sometimes a twist.

★ MEMORY TRICK: "FEW"

Few characters · **E**ssential moment (one conflict + turning point) · **W**here & when are limited (one setting, short time) – and it starts and ends *open*.

Other typical elements

Symbols

Objects that stand for something bigger (a closed door = loneliness).

Everyday life

Ordinary people in ordinary situations.

Dense language

Short, precise, suggestive – much is only hinted at.

⚠ IN THE TEST

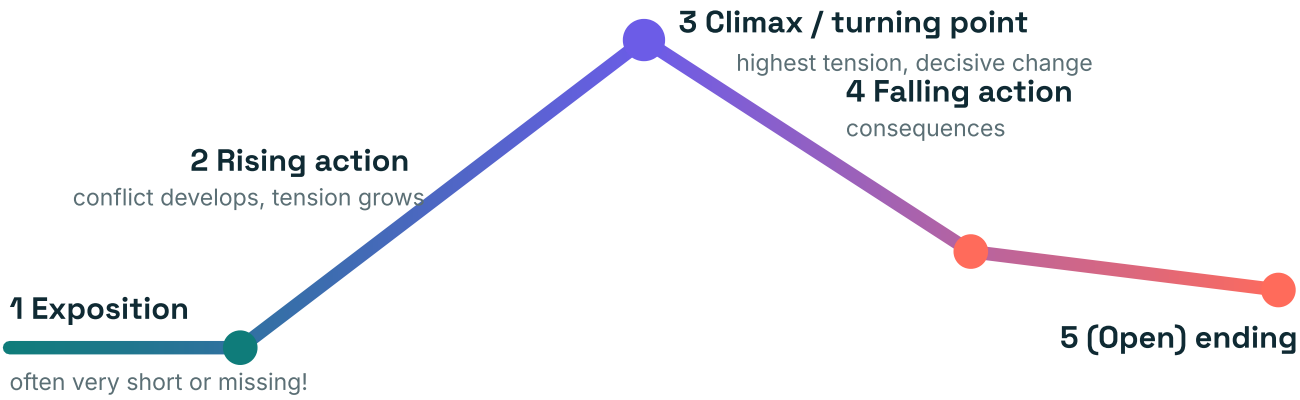
Don't just *list* features – **prove** them with the text! E.g.: *"The story begins in medias res, as the reader is immediately confronted with Maya at the bus stop without any introduction (cf. l. 1)."*

01

TOPIC ONE · CONTINUED

Plot Structure & Key Terms

The plot curve (Freytag's pyramid)



Characters

Term	Meaning
protagonist	main character
antagonist	character / force that works against the protagonist
round vs. **flat** character	complex, many traits vs. simple, only one or two traits
dynamic vs. **static** character	changes / develops during the story vs. stays the same
direct characterization	the narrator or another character *tells* us what someone is like (*"She was shy."*)
indirect characterization	we find out through actions, speech, looks, thoughts (*"She stared at her shoes."*)

Conflict, setting & theme

Conflict

external: character vs. character / society / nature
internal: a struggle inside a character's mind

Setting

where + **when** the story takes place. Creates the **atmosphere** (mood): tense, gloomy, cheerful...

Theme

The central idea or message (e.g. loneliness, growing up, family, prejudice).

◆ PLOT VS. STORY

Story = what happens in chronological order. **Plot** = how the events are arranged and connected (cause & effect). Watch out for **flashbacks** (going back in time) and **foreshadowing** (hints at what will happen).

02

TOPIC TWO

Writing a Summary

A summary tells the reader **briefly and objectively** what a text is about. Someone who has not read the story should understand the main events afterwards.

Step 1 – The introductory sentence (the "TATT" sentence)

T	A	T	T
Type of text (short story)	**A**uthor	**T**itle (+ year if given)	**T**opic / main idea (in one sentence)

*In the short story "**Title**" (**year**), written by **author**, a teenage girl learns that... / the author describes how... / it is about...*

Step 2 – The main part

Summarise the **most important events** in a logical (usually chronological) order. Leave out details, examples and descriptions. Connect the ideas with linking words.

✓ Do

- ✓ **simple present** (present perfect for earlier events)
- ✓ use **your own words**
- ✓ **3rd person**, neutral style
- ✓ **reported speech** instead of dialogue
- ✓ only the **key events** (~⅓ of the original or less)
- ✓ linking words: *first, then, after that, when, as, because, finally, in the end*

× Don't

- × no past tense (*"she went" → "she goes"*)
- × no quotations
- × no direct speech
- × no personal opinion / evaluation (*"I think...", "sadly..."*)
- × no interpretation or analysis
- × no details (names of minor characters, exact times, descriptions)
- × no suspense – no "cliffhanger"

Step 3 – Check

Tense? Own words? Opinion-free? Is the ending of the story included? Is it short enough?

↻ DIRECT SPEECH → REPORTED SPEECH

"I'm not waiting for the bus," he says. → He **explains that he is not waiting** for the bus.
"Aren't you coming?" she asks. → She **asks him whether he is coming**.
Useful verbs: explain claim admit reveal suggest complain wonder refuse

03

TOPIC THREE

Narrative Perspectives

⚠ GOLDEN RULE

The **narrator ≠ the author!** The narrator is a voice invented by the author to tell the story. Never write *"The author says that he..."* when you mean the narrator.

Ask two questions: ① **Who tells the story?** (inside or outside the story?) ② **How much does the narrator know?** (thoughts of everyone, one person, or nobody?)

"I / we" First-person narrator

A character **inside** the story tells it. Only knows **his/her own** thoughts and feelings; limited view.

Variants: I-narrator as **protagonist** (tells own story) or as **observer** (minor character telling someone else's story).

Effect: close, personal, the reader identifies with the narrator – but it is **subjective** and can be **unreliable**.

"he / she" Third-person omniscient

An all-knowing narrator **outside** the story. Knows thoughts and feelings of **all** characters, past and future; may comment on events.

Signals: jumps between characters' minds, comments, "Little did he know..."

Effect: overview, the reader knows more than the characters → suspense, irony; but more distance.

"he / she" Third-person limited

Also called *personal* narrator. Narrator outside the story, but the story is told through the eyes of **one** character – only **their** thoughts and feelings are shown.

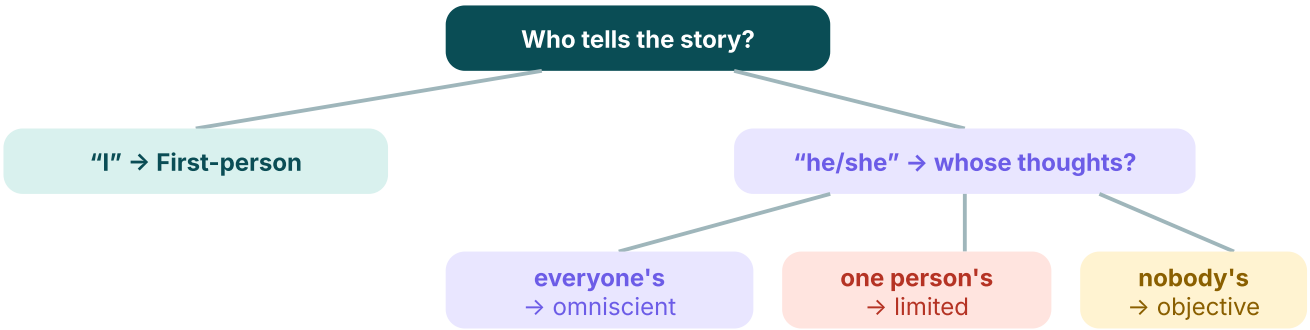
Effect: the reader identifies with this character and shares their limited knowledge → suspense, sympathy.

"he / she" Objective / neutral narrator

Like a **camera** ("camera-eye"): only describes what can be **seen and heard** – actions, dialogue. No thoughts, no comments.

Effect: distance, very realistic; the reader has to **interpret** feelings themselves.

Quick decision tree



03

TOPIC THREE · CONTINUED

Point of View in Action

Same scene – four perspectives

Perspective	Example
First-person	*I stared at the letter. My hands were shaking – I knew what it said before I even opened it.*
3rd-person omniscient	*Jack stared at the letter, terrified. In the kitchen, his mother was smiling – she had no idea that the letter would change everything.*
3rd-person limited	*Jack stared at the letter. Why were his hands shaking? He knew what it said before he even opened it.*
Objective	*Jack stared at the letter. His hands were shaking. He put it on the table and walked to the window.*

Narrative techniques you might notice

Interior monologue

A character's thoughts presented directly, in the first person, as if we "hear" them.

Stream of consciousness

A chaotic flow of thoughts and feelings – incomplete sentences, jumps.

Unreliable narrator

A (mostly first-person) narrator we can't fully trust – lies, misjudges, is biased.

Phrases for the test

Naming the perspective

- The story is told by a **first-person / third-person … narrator**.
- The story is told from the **point of view** of …
- The narrator only reveals **the thoughts and feelings** of …
- This becomes clear in line … where …

Explaining the effect

- As a result, the reader **can identify with** …
- This **creates suspense / distance / sympathy** because …
- The reader knows **as little as / more than** the protagonist.
- This **emphasises / underlines** the protagonist's …

★ THE PERFECT ANSWER = 3 STEPS

① **Name it** (which narrator?) → ② **Prove it** (quote + line) → ③ **Explain the effect** (what does it do to the reader?).

"The story is told by a third-person limited narrator, as only Maya's thoughts are revealed: 'She did not want to call her father' (l. 3). As a result, the reader shares her feelings of guilt and can sympathise with her."

PRACTICE

Exercises

Exercise 1 · True or false?

Features ●○○

1. Short stories usually have many main characters and several plot lines. T F
2. A short story often begins *in medias res*. T F
3. The action of a short story normally takes place over many years. T F
4. Many short stories have an open ending. T F
5. A "flat" character develops and changes during the story. T F
6. The turning point is the moment of highest tension. T F
7. "She slammed the door and didn't say a word" is indirect characterization. T F
8. The narrator of a story is always the author. T F

Exercise 2 · Who's talking?

Perspectives ●●○

Identify the narrative perspective of each excerpt and name **one signal** that helped you.

a. *I knew I shouldn't have opened the box, but my fingers were already tearing at the tape.*

b. *Tom walked into the room and sat down. Sarah looked at the clock. Neither of them spoke.*

c. *Little did the villagers know that the stranger would change their lives forever. Miles away, his sister was packing her bags, unaware of the danger.*

d. *Lena stared at the test. Why hadn't she studied? The clock on the wall seemed to tick louder with every second.*

e. *My neighbour, Mr Grant, was the strangest man I had ever met. Every morning at six, he watered his plastic flowers.*

f. *The old woman smiled at the boy, who felt ashamed. She thought he looked just like her late husband, but she said nothing.*

Exercise 3 · Switch the camera

Perspectives ●●●

Rewrite excerpt **(a)** from Exercise 2 ① as a **third-person limited** narrator and ② as an **objective** narrator. What changes for the reader?

PRACTICE · CONTINUED

Exercises

Exercise 4 · Report it!

Summary skills ●●○

Turn the direct speech into reported speech (present tense, like in a summary). Use a fitting reporting verb.

1. *"I'm sorry, I lost your phone," Ben says to his sister.*
2. *"Can you help me with my homework?" Mia asks her brother.*
3. *"Don't go out in the storm!" the mother tells the children.*
4. *"Yes, I stole the money," the boy says.*

Exercise 5 · Fix the summary

Summary ●●●

This summary of the story on the next page breaks **at least 7 rules**. Find and correct the mistakes.

This story is really sad and I liked it a lot. Maya was waiting at a bus stop at 9:47 because she had a fight with her dad at dinner. An old man with a red scarf and a coat that is too big sits on the bench and hums a song. He says: "My son used to wait here. He played football over at the park." Maya feels bad. Then the bus comes, but she decides to stay, which was a very brave decision. What will she do next? You have to read it to find out!

⏱ YOUR 45-MINUTE PLAN FOR THE TEST

5' Read the tasks first, then the text

10' Read again, mark key events & quotes, take notes

25' Write: summary → features → perspective

5' Check tense, spelling, line references

EXERCISE 6 · FULL MOCK TEST · 45 MINUTES

The Red Scarf

A short story written for this study guide.

It was already dark when Maya reached the bus stop. Her phone showed 9:47 – the last bus would come in three minutes, and if she missed it, she would have to call her father. She did not want to call her father. Not after what she had said to him at dinner.

An old man was sitting on the bench, wrapped in a coat that looked too big for him. A red scarf hung loosely around his neck. He was humming a song Maya did not know.

"Cold night," he said without looking at her.

Maya nodded and put in her earphones, although no music was playing.

The old man kept humming. Then he stopped. "My son used to wait here," he said. "Every Friday. He played football over at the park." He pointed into the darkness. "I always told him he was late. Every single time. I never told him I was proud of him."

Maya took one earphone out. She wanted to say something, but the words got stuck somewhere between her throat and her mouth.

"He lives in Canada now," the man went on. "We talk at Christmas. Sometimes."

Headlights appeared at the end of the street. The bus. Maya stood up. The old man did not move.

"Aren't you coming?" she asked.

He smiled. "I'm not waiting for the bus."

The doors opened with a hiss. Maya looked at the warm, bright inside of the bus, then at the old man, then at her phone. The driver was waiting.

She stepped back from the curb and let the doors close.

The bus drove away. Maya unlocked her phone and scrolled to "Dad". Her thumb hovered over the name for a long moment.

Next to her, the old man began to hum again.

Tasks

~45 min

1. **Summarise** the short story. (intro sentence + main part, approx. 100–130 words)
2. **Show** that "The Red Scarf" has typical features of a short story. Refer to the text. (at least 4 features)
3. **Analyse** the narrative perspective and explain its effect on the reader.
4. Bonus What could the red scarf and the bus symbolise? Explain the ending.

DON'T PEEK TOO EARLY!

Answer Key

Exercise 1

1 **F** (few characters, one plot line) · 2 **T** · 3 **F** (short time span) · 4 **T** · 5 **F** (that's a dynamic character; flat = simple, few traits) · 6 **T** · 7 **T** (we learn about her through her actions) · 8 **F** (narrator ≠ author)

Exercise 2

	Perspective	Signal
a	**first-person** (protagonist)	"I", "my"; own thoughts (*I knew…*)
b	**objective / neutral**	only actions, no thoughts or feelings – like a camera
c	**third-person omniscient**	knows the future (*would change…*), jumps to another place, comments
d	**third-person limited**	"she", but only Lena's thoughts (*Why hadn't she studied?*)
e	**first-person** (observer)	"I", but tells the story of someone else (Mr Grant)
f	**third-person omniscient**	shows the feelings of *two* characters (boy feels ashamed + woman's thoughts)

Exercise 3 (example)

Limited: *She knew she shouldn't have opened the box, but her fingers were already tearing at the tape.* → we still get her thoughts, but with a little more distance.
Objective: *She looked at the box for a moment. Then she began to tear at the tape.* → no thoughts, the reader has to guess her feelings; more distance and mystery.

Exercise 4

1. Ben **apologises** to his sister and **admits that he has lost** her phone.
2. Mia **asks** her brother **whether / if he can help** her with her homework.
3. The mother **warns** the children **not to go out** in the storm.
4. The boy **admits / confesses that he has stolen** the money.

Exercise 5 – the mistakes

- × No introductory sentence (type, title, author, topic missing)
- × Personal opinion: *"really sad", "I liked it", "very brave decision"*
- × Wrong tense: *was waiting, had → is waiting, has had*; *was → is*
- × Unnecessary details: *9:47, coat that is too big, hums a song*
- × Direct speech / quotation → reported speech
- × Vague / too short on key point: *"Maya feels bad"* – why? (she thinks of her father)
- × Missing ending (she is about to call her dad) + rhetorical question / cliffhanger at the end

ANSWER KEY · MOCK TEST

Model Answers

Task 1 – Model summary

The short story "The Red Scarf" is about a teenage girl whose encounter with a lonely old man at a bus stop makes her rethink an argument with her father. One evening, Maya is waiting for the last bus home because she wants to avoid calling her father after an argument with him. At the bus stop, an old man starts talking to her. He tells her that his son used to wait there and admits that he never told him he was proud of him. Now his son lives abroad and they hardly talk. When the bus arrives, Maya realises that the man is not waiting for it. She decides not to get on and lets the bus leave. In the end, she is about to call her father.

→ present tense ✓ own words ✓ no opinion ✓ ending included ✓ (~110 words)

Task 2 – Features (examples)

Feature	Evidence
sudden beginning	starts directly at the bus stop, no introduction of Maya (l. 1)
few characters	only Maya and the old man (+ the father/son only mentioned)
one setting, short time	a bus stop; only a few minutes (9:47 – bus arrives)
one conflict	Maya's (internal) conflict about her argument with her father
turning point	she steps back and lets the bus go (l. 23) – moment of insight
open ending	we don't know if she really calls her dad (ll. 24–26)
symbols	the bus = a chance that you can miss; the red scarf = warmth / love that is not shown

Task 3 – Narrative perspective

The story is told by a **third-person limited narrator**. We only learn **Maya's** thoughts and feelings, e.g. *"She did not want to call her father"* (l. 3) or *"She wanted to say something, but the words got stuck"* (ll. 14f.). The old man's thoughts are never revealed – we only know what he says and does. **Effect:** the reader experiences the situation through Maya's eyes, shares her guilt and can sympathise with her. Because the old man remains a mystery (*"I'm not waiting for the bus"*), suspense is created and the reader has to interpret his situation themselves.

Bonus – Symbols & ending

The **bus** can stand for a chance that passes – Maya consciously lets it go to take another chance: talking to her dad. The **old man** mirrors what could happen to her and her father if they never talk. The open ending suggests that Maya has learned something (epiphany), but the reader must decide whether she makes the call.

★ LAST-MINUTE CHECKLIST

- ☐ I can name 6+ features of short stories
- ☐ I always use the simple present in a summary
- ☐ I know the 4 narrative perspectives
- ☐ I explain the **effect** on the reader
- ☐ I can write a TATT intro sentence
- ☐ I can change direct into reported speech
- ☐ I always prove with quotes + line numbers
- ☐ I remember: narrator ≠ author!